Technical Debt Management Process

For long running projects, especially with large (and/or changing teams), technical debt is unavoidable. However, like other debt, it's only bad if you don't pay it down or are irresponsible in accumulating it. Good news is there is practice on how to tackle it.

The spreadsheet below is used to track and manage technical debt items across the project. Each row represents a specific tech debt issue that needs to be addressed. Here's how the process works:

1. Identification

Column: Description / Identified (when) / Owner

- Team members (e.g., developers, QA, architect) log technical debt items as soon as they're identified.
- The person responsible for reporting the item is noted as the Owner, along with the date it was discovered.

2. Assessment

Column: Estimate / Priority / Status

- Each item is roughly estimated (e.g., in hours or story points). If that is not possible at the moment of tech debt logging – keep the column empty.
- The priority is marked (e.g., *Critical, High, Mid, Low*) to help with triage.
- The current status is tracked (e.g., *Active*, Closed, On hold).

3. Planning

- The team reviews this sheet regularly (e.g., during plannings or scope groomings). In Sigma DSP team case – it can be reviewed on Mondays timeline calls (at least biweekly).
- If an item is selected for work, it's moved to Jira and assigned a Jira ticket ID.

4. Execution

- The Owner or an assigned developer addresses the issue within the estimated effort.
- Progress is tracked via the Status column.

5. Comments & Documentation

- Additional context, blockers, or decisions are captured in the Comments column.

- This helps keep a record of discussions or dependencies around each tech debt item.